Lesson 11: The Paragraph 2: Unity, Transitions and Concluding Sentences

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 3 Parts and Characteristics of a Good Paragraph (sections VII-XI).

In this lesson

In Lesson 8 you studied the paragraph format, its parts, the title and the topic sentence. Now you will study the rest: supporting sentences and details, transitions and concluding sentences, and three characteristics of a good paragraph: unity, cohesion and completion. You will finish with a complete paragraph of your own.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Plan supporting ideas by predicting the readers' question about the topic sentence.
- Check an outline or a paragraph for unity and remove irrelevant ideas.
- Recognize four types of supporting details.
- Use transitions to give a paragraph cohesion.
- Write a concluding sentence and check that a paragraph is complete.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
supporting details	facts, reasons, experts' opinions and examples that explain a supporting sentence	a quote by writer Barbara Dana
unity	all the supporting sentences work together to explain the main idea	A sunflower in a rose bouquet breaks the unity.
ir·REL·e·vant	not related, having nothing to do with the main idea	Cross out the irrelevant ideas.
cohesion	the link between ideas, so that they flow naturally from one to the next	Imagine cohesion as a waterfall.
transition	a connecting word or phrase that shows how ideas are related	first, moreover, finally, in brief
completion	the paragraph has every necessary part and explains every predictor	If any one part is missing, the paragraph is incomplete.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
re·STATE	write again, repeat	The conclusion restates the main idea in different words.
con·VINC·ing	making people believe	Supporting sentences make your paragraph interesting and convincing.
TOL·er·ant	accepting differences	Good roommates help each other become more caring, supportive, and tolerant.
DIS·ci·plined	self-controlled, strict with oneself	I forced myself to be more disciplined.

Rules and explanations

Supporting sentences

Supporting sentences "hold up" the main idea, like a bridge holding up a man: they must support or explain the main idea in the topic sentence. A good strategy is to **predict the question the readers may ask** about your topic sentence. The answers are your supporting ideas, and the result is your outline (Lesson 4). Example: *Young people should not live in their parents' house after graduating from college*. Question: Why not? Supports: practice independence in daily life; experience real meaning of life; learn to appreciate parents.

Unity

Unity comes from the verb "unite". In a paragraph, it means that all the supporting sentences serve the same purpose: explaining the main idea. One sunflower in a bouquet of roses looks out of place; so does one irrelevant idea in a paragraph. To check unity:

- Ask: "Does each supporting sentence explain the **controlling idea** in the topic sentence?" If not, delete or change it. Circle the controlling idea to make checking easier.
- Always make an outline first. Put any new idea into the outline and ask the same question.

The book's example (*Taking online classes helps college students in three significant ways*.): "hard to focus because of noisy children", "not get professor's in-person help" and "difficult materials, questions not answered right away" do not show how online classes **help**, and "manage time better" repeats Support 2. The book crosses these words out in the improved outline.

Types of supporting details

- **facts:** numbers, general truths, scientific truths
- **reasons:** logical explanations
- **experts' opinions:** research findings, quotes by experts in the field
- **examples:** stories of well-known people, personal experiences, personal quotes

In "Good Roommates", the details are personal examples of Abia and the writer (all three supports), a quote by an expert (writer Barbara Dana, in Support 2), and a general truth and logic (Support 3).

Transitions and cohesion

Cohesion means the ideas flow smoothly, like a waterfall. Transitions (connecting words) organize the writer's thoughts and guide the readers, between the supporting sentences and inside them.

- A transition for the **first** supporting idea is often optional.
- "Finally" shows the **last supporting idea** in the body. It is not used right before the conclusion.
- A transition before the concluding sentence is optional; it is more common without one.
- Most transitions are followed by a comma, but not all (different types have different punctuation rules).
- Do not overuse transitions, or the paragraph will sound unnatural.

Meaning	Transitions
Addition	first, second, then, next, in addition, also, furthermore, moreover, last, finally
Contrast	but, yet, on the other hand, on the contrary, however, nevertheless, though, even though, although
Time	first, then, next, after that, soon, in the beginning, at first, at last, before, after, later, when, while, until
Reason	for, due to, because of, because, since, as
Result	so, therefore, thus, consequently, as a result
Location	near, beside, next to, in front, behind, around, under, opposite, above, below
Conclusion	in conclusion, in summary, to sum up, in brief, for those reasons
Example	like, such as, including, for example, for instance

Concluding sentences

A concluding sentence signals the end of the paragraph. You can write one to three sentences that:

- **restate** the main idea in different words or sentence structure;
- **summarize** the main points of the body;
- express an **opinion**, make a **prediction**, give a **recommendation**, or ask a **question** related to the topic.

A conclusion must **not** bring up a new topic. Wrong: *For those three reasons, I enjoy swimming the most. I will also start playing basketball next week.*

The book's examples for the topic sentence *Swimming is my favorite hobby.*:

- restate: For those three reasons, I enjoy swimming the most.
- restate + summarize: For the benefits of physical health, mental wellbeing, and social life, I enjoy swimming the most.
- restate + opinion: (restatement +) It is the activity that has kept me healthy in the last ten years.
- restate + question: (restatement +) Shouldn't everyone start this hobby, too?

Paragraph completion

A paragraph is complete when it has a title, a topic sentence, details for every predictor, proper transitions and a concluding sentence. If one part is missing, it is incomplete. The book's jogging paragraph has no title, and its topic sentence promises physical, mental and social benefits, but the social benefits are never explained.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic texts often link many sentences with "and" (wa). In English, use the transition that shows the real relationship (however, for example, as a result...), and do not start sentence after sentence with "And".

Practice

Exercise 5. Unity in outlines. Which supporting ideas or details are irrelevant? Cross them out and say why.

1. Topic sentence: *During Covid pandemic, social distancing was important in preventing the spread of coronavirus*. Supports: lower chance of passing the virus (talking, sneezing, coughing, passing one person to the next); the virus highly contagious (through physical contact, Delta variant 60% more transmissible than the one before); hospitals with good medical equipment (ICU, respirators, oxygen tanks, N95 masks); some people catching virus easily (sick people, older people, children).
2. Topic sentence: *I suffered from severe mental stress during the Covid 19 lockdown in April 2020*. Supports: worry about my health and the health of my family (brother essential worker, baby at home); worry about money (lost restaurant job, pay bills, good unemployment benefits); online classes very hard (convenient time, hard to learn Blackboard, no face-to-face practice, missed deadline of first assignment).
3. Topic sentence: *My cousin did not want to get the Covid-19 vaccine for three reasons*. Supports: vaccine safety not sure (developed in a short time, worry about reactions and long-term side effects, reports about blood clots); he's healthy (strong, seldom sick, good immunity); stayed home all the time (not contact other people, study online, get bored, want to have parties with friends).

Exercise 7. Unity in a paragraph. Read "My Special Place" (lesson material). Sentence 4 is irrelevant (example). Find four more sentences that should be deleted.

Exercise 8. Types of details. Read "No Capital Punishment". What are the three supporting ideas? What types of details does the writer use for each?

Exercise 9. "My Daughter". Choose transitions from the list for the blanks (one each; not all are needed): first, second, next, in addition, also, furthermore, moreover, last, finally, for example, to sum up. Example: *Second*, Amy has many hobbies.

1. _____, Amy has a tender heart.
2. _____, when I am cooking, Amy plays with Sonia and keeps her company.
3. She is _____ kind to little animals.
4. _____, with Amy's loving personality, she has many friends.

5. _____, I am proud of my daughter.

Exercise 10. "My Valuable Life Lesson". Choose from: however, on the first Saturday, then, after crying for an hour, while I was eating breakfast, now, at night, finally, after that, after I arrived. Example: *After I arrived*, everything happened fast.

1. _____, the new family left me alone in the house all day.
2. _____, I felt more lonely than ever.
3. It was coming as a pressure on my head, and _____ I started crying.
4. _____, I didn't have a choice now because I was living in someone else's home.
5. _____ I was alone in an unfamiliar house, in a faraway country, their teaching felt so comforting.
6. _____, I finally stopped to think about why the current situation was affecting my feelings.

Exercise 11. Concluding sentences. What methods do the concluding sentences of these paragraphs use, and how do they relate to the topic sentences?

1. "Good Roommates" 2. "No Capital Punishment" 3. "My Daughter"

Exercise 12. Completion. Is the paragraph about unleashed dogs ("Unleashed dogs are dangerous to the environment, other living beings, and even to themselves.") complete? If not, what is missing?

Speak with your tutor

- "I will read you my outline. Ask me the readers' question about my topic sentence, then check every supporting idea for unity."
- "Here is my concluding sentence and my topic sentence: [paste]. Which methods did I use? Did I bring up a new topic?"
- "Check my colour coding of 'Three Benefits of Online Classes for College Students' (Exercise 13) and my answers to its questions."

Writing task

A complete paragraph (the book's Exercise 6 and NSNT Practice). Choose one topic sentence from Exercise 6 (for example, "People 18 years and older should serve two years in the military." or "Men can often be better care givers than women."), or use your childhood paragraph from Lesson 8.

1. Write the readers' question and an outline with three supporting ideas and details. Check every idea for unity.
2. Write (or rewrite) the paragraph, about 200 words, with a title, the topic sentence, supporting sentences with different types of details, transitions, and a concluding sentence.

Self-editing checklist

- Does every supporting sentence explain the controlling idea (unity)?
- Did I use at least two types of details (facts, reasons, experts' opinions, examples)?
- Did I use transitions with the right meaning, a comma after most of them, and not too many?

- Is "Finally" used for the last supporting idea? Does my conclusion restate the main idea without a new topic?
- Is the paragraph complete: title, topic sentence, every predictor explained, details, transitions, conclusion?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 5

1. Cross out "hospitals with good medical equipment" and its details (ICU, respirators, oxygen tanks, N95 masks). They are about treating sick people, not about why social distancing prevents the spread. The last support then becomes Support 3 (the book labels it "Supporting Sentence 3" twice).
2. Cross out "good unemployment benefits" and "convenient time". They are positive things, so they do not explain the stress.
3. Cross out "get bored" and "want to have parties with friends". They do not explain why he did not want the vaccine.

Exercise 7 (book) 4 (example), 9, 12, 13, 18

Exercise 8 (example answer)

- Support 1: the result is irreversible. Details: logic (guilt cannot always be proved with 100% certainty) and a question (What if a person is wrongly charged?).
- Support 2: capital punishment is killing. Details: reasons and general beliefs (killing is wrong; life is sacred).
- Support 3: it does not stop crime. Details: facts with numbers from a newspaper report (over 100 people shot in Chicago on one weekend in July 2021) and logic.

Exercise 9 (book)

1. In addition / Furthermore / Next / Moreover 2. For example 3. also 4. Finally / Last 5. To sum up

Exercise 10 (book)

1. On the first Saturday 2. While I was eating breakfast 3. then 4. However 5. Now 6. After crying for an hour

Exercise 11 (example answers)

1. Topic sentence: "Having good roommates makes lives more enjoyable." The conclusion summarizes the three points (caring, supportive, tolerant) and restates the main idea in different words ("They make living easier in this complicated world").
2. The conclusion restates the main idea in different words ("death penalty should not be supported" = "should be banned") and gives a recommendation (the people and the government must find a better solution).
3. Topic sentence: "My daughter is a wonderful girl." The conclusion restates it in different words and expresses an opinion: "I am proud of my daughter. She is a blessing to people around her."

Exercise 12 It is not complete: there is **no title** and **no concluding sentence**. (All three predictors are explained, with transitions.) The book's complete version in Lesson 5 has the title "Leash Your Dog!" and the conclusion "For safety reasons, owners should always keep their dogs on a leash in public."

My notes